Between the Lines

By James Still

Jenny: Almost 18
Ran: Her sister, 14 (or younger).

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1:	*Dealing with an older sibling leaving for college, can be a difficult adjustment.*
ACTRESS 2:	*The experts say to skip the whole act where you pretend that you "don't care" about where they're going and that you won't say goodbye. Truth is: you're in denial.*
ACTRESS 1:	*You don't want to admit that life as you know it is about to end.*
ACTRESS 2:	*You should realize that your sibling, while definitely excited to embark on this new adventure, is probably really scared and could definitely use your support.*
ACTRESS 1:	*The worst thing you could do is pretend that you don't care because they might think that you don't care about them.*
TOGETHER:	*It's hard for everyone to read Between the Lines by James Still*

At Rise: Jenny looks around the room, distracted. She packs a couple of suitcases, rolls up posters, chooses CDs. There's a knock at the door.

JENNY: Yeah?

RAN: Jenny? It's me.

JENNY: Hi, me (Continues packing. She looks over at the closed door.) Ran? What are you doing?

RAN: Nothing.

JENNY: Then stop spying on me and com in.

RAN: Okay. (Ran comes in the room, plops on the bed)

JENNY: Why are you being so weird?

RAN: I'm not being weird. And I wasn't spying.

JENNY: Okay.

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RAN: What are you doing?

JENNY: What does it look like I'm doing? I'm packing.

RAN: Oh.

JENNY: And I don't need any help, because I'm almost finished.

RAN: That's good, because I wasn't planning on helping. (Beat) Are you nervous?

JENNY: No. Are you?

RAN: Why should I be nervous? You're the one who's leaving. I'm the one who's staying.

JENNY: Maybe that's why you're nervous

RAN: I'm not nervous.

JENNY: Then stop tapping your foot. (Ran looks at her foot unconsciously tapping the floor. She stops tapping). Think you're going to miss me? (Ran doesn't answer. Jenny looks at her, smiles, lets it pass.) I found a book that was due six months ago. It was under my bed next to a piece of pizza that looked like a dead animal.

RAN: Gross.

JENNY: It still tasted pretty good. (Ran looks at Jenny, horrified. Jenny laughs loud). Gotcha! (beat)

RAN: What do you think it'll be like?

JENNY: What?

RAN: College.

JENNY: How should I know? I've never been to college. (Ran starts tapping her foot again. Jenny walks over and puts her hand on her foot to stop it from tapping.) It'll probably be like high school – only harder.

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RAN: And more fun.

JENNY: Hopefully.

RAN: What if you don't like your roommate?

JENNY: I don't know. But after sharing this room with you for most of my life, I think I'm ready for anything.

RAN: Am I really that bad?

JENNY: The best.

RAN: The best?

JENNY: The best at being bad.

RAN: The best at being bad. I like that. (Beat) Remember when I brought that tarantula home?

JENNY: The one you named "Kevin"?

RAN: Right. He just looked like a Kevin, you know?

JENNY: He just looked like a big, hairy, poisonous spider, you know?

RAN: Kinda like that guy you had a crush on in tenth grade. (Beat) I'm not going to miss you, Jenny. But if I did, it would be awful. I mean, what if you left and I felt really, really bad and I couldn't stand the idea of not sharing a room with you, of not talking to you late at night when Mom and Dad thought we were asleep . . . of not having somebody . . . (her voice trails off).

JENNY: Com on, Ran, how many times have you wished you could have this room all to yourself?

RAN: Six thousand two hundred and eighty-six times. At least.

JENNY: Well . . . careful what you wish for.

RAN: Remember when you used to lock me out –

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JENNY: And you'd climb on the roof –

RAN: And come in through the window –

JENNY: Wearing a mask that looked like the pope.

RAN: I think I had green hair then too.

JENNY: Oh yeah – Ran's Green Hair.

RAN: I liked it.

JENNY: I know you did. But sometimes I'd wake up in the middle of the night because a bright light was shining in my eyes. Only it turned out to be your neon green hair glowing in the dark.

RAN: My green hair glowed in the dark? Cool. (Beat) Maybe I'll paint the walls black. After you're gone.

JENNY: Why?

RAN: Why not? (Jenny laughs) What's so funny?

JENNY: We're really different, you know?

RAN: Remember when you had me convinced that I was adopted?

JENNY: It was a joke!

RAN: I know, but I believed you. And so I started asking everybody in town if they knew who my real parents were. I went right up to the Methodist minister and said, "Are you my father?"

JENNY: I thought Mom was going to die of embarrassment.

RAN: Well, they never had the blood tests. Who knows? Maybe it's true.

JENNY: No way. You're definitely my sister.

RAN: Why?

JENNY: I don't know. It's just something you know. It's something you can feel. It's like you share something – even though you don't know what

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it is. It's just something inside, you know? Something that feels . . . connected.

RAN: Connected to what?

JENNY: Ran!

RAN: I'm just trying to understand what you're talking about.

JENNY: Forget it.

RAN: Are you mad at me?

JENNY: Do you want me to be?

RAN: What is that supposed to mean?

JENNY: Oh come on, Ran. You always act so tough, it's like you're daring me to be mean or something. And now I'm moving away and going to college – and I think you want me to be mean so you can be made at me.

RAN: Whatever.

JENNY: Because it's a lot easier not to miss somebody if you're mad at them.

RAN: (Angry) I am not mad at you!

JENNY: (Stares at Ran.) Okay. (Picks up an old stuffed animal and looks at it tenderly.) Do you want this?

RAN: You don't want it?

JENNY: I thought you liked it.

RAN: I used to. When I was like, six. (A horn honks off-stage).

JENNY: I guess Dad is ready to go.

RAN: Either that or he's just checking to make sure the horn still works. (Beat)

JENNY: You could still come, you know.

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RAN: (Thinks about it) No. It's your day. Besides, I hate it when Mom cries.

JENNY: Do you think she's going to cry?

RAN: Duh. I heard her crying last night. She's going to really really miss you. (Beat)

JENNY: So

RAN: So this is it. You're shipping out. College girl.

JENNY: Woman

RAN: Whatever

JENNY: (Taking a look around the room.) Are you really going to paint the room black after I'm gone?

RAN: No.

JENNY: Good

RAN: I'm going to paint it hot pink. With psychedelic murals on every wall. And on the ceiling, I'm going to paint the solar system. All the planets and all the moons and all the stars. And if I'm in the mood, I'll paint some extra planets and give them names like "Popcorn" and "secrets" and . . . "Jenny."

JENNY: Okay. (She reaches out to give Ran a hug and Ran slips away and starts circling Jenny). What are you doing?

RAN: I'm a moon. Orbiting around Planet Jenny. I'm an asteroid! (She crashed into Jenny and manages to turn it into an awkward hug. Ran doesn't want to let go.)

JENNY: You're a nut.

RAN: Does that mean you're not going to go?

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JENNY: Ran . . .

RAN: You could stay. I could bring you food, you could write all my papers and do my homework for me. I'll keep my side of the room spotless. . . (The horn honks again. Ran finally lets go of Jenny. Jenny picks up the stuffed animal and gives it to Ran)

JENNY: Look after him for me. (To the stuffed animal) You're going to miss me, aren't you? I hope somebody does. (She grabs her suitcases and exits the room. Ran cradles the animal)

RAN: (To herself) Somebody does.

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